the executive and the judiciary to be equally involved in the exercise.

That said, there is an altered perception about which of the 'four pillars' has best upheld democratic norms, with 16.1 per cent admonishing all, up from 10.2 per cent in January 2022. There is a drop in those backing the judiciary from 34 per cent to 28.7 per cent, for the executive from 10.4 per cent to 7.2 per cent, and the sharpest in the case of the media: from 20.3 per cent to 10.8 per cent. In the same period, the perception about the role of the legislature in upholding democratic norms is up from 13.4 per cent to 18.4 per cent.

Further putting the spotlight on the state of democracy, 46.2 per cent of the respondents perceive it's in danger, up from 42 per cent in January 2021. The fact that opinions have crystallised over this period becomes evident from the significant drop in the percentage of those who believe democracy is not in danger—from 47 per cent to 38.8 per cent. But still, a sizeable number of the respondents—46.7 per cent—feel free to express their opinion on politics and religion, though down from 49.8 per cent in August 2022. Another 21.8 per cent feel free to express opinions on politics but not religion, while 8.3 per cent feel free to express opinions on religion but not politics. For those who feel inhibited on either count, the percentage has gone up from 9.4 per cent to 11.4 per cent.

A similar trend emerges in the case of communal harmony. Has it improved under the present regime? Only 43.6 per cent think so, down from 55 per cent in January 2021, while 8.1 per cent say it's the same, down from 18 per cent. In fact, the percentage of those who feel the situation has deteriorated has climbed from 22 to 32.7 in the same period. As for who is responsible, nearly a third, or 31 per cent, blame the BJP and its ideological fountainhead Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), and just 5 per cent point the finger at the Opposition parties. Another 3.2 per cent believe religious fundamentalists have played a key role and 2.9 per cent lay the blame at the media and social media's door.

Perceptions about India's biggest minority community are also changing, with fewer respondents believing that Muslim men are indulging in 'love jihad', that is marrying Hindu women as part of a larger conspiracy to turn India into an Islamic state. The latest MOTN poll shows that 42.1 per cent feel that's the case, down from 53.1 per cent a year ago. At the same time, the percentage of those who do not believe in any such conspiracy is up from 33.3 to 40.2.

But are women safe in India, in general? Well, it's becoming less safe over the years, at least in the perception of the MOTN respondents—41.6 per cent of those polled believe so, in comparison to 32 per cent in January 2021. But 43.1 per cent of the respondents still feel the country is safe for women, down from 45 per cent, and 10.5 per cent believe the situation has been the same, a significant drop from 21 per cent.

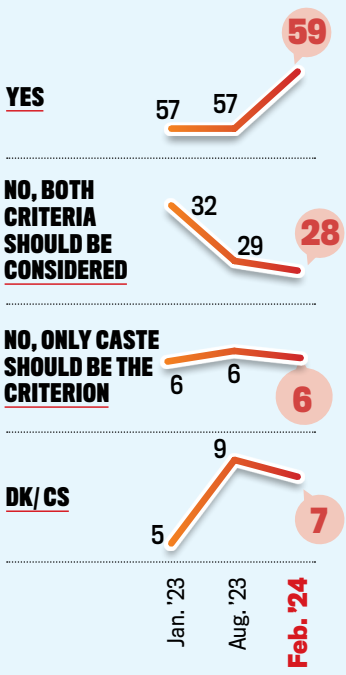
Nonetheless, social mores are changing in India, albeit slowly. Those supporting inter-caste marriages, without any caveats, account for 37.6 per cent of the respondents, up from 37.2 per cent a year ago. The percentage of those who are okay with it only if the caste identity is known to both parties has, in fact, declined from 39 per cent to 34.3 per cent in the same period. The same is the case with inter-religion marriages. Those endorsing it are marginal-

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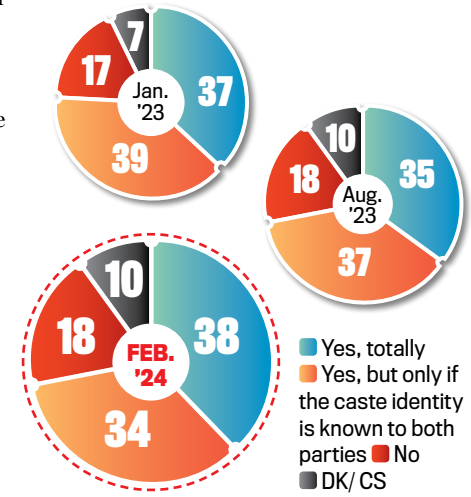
PERCENTAGE POINTS

DROP IN THOSE WHO FEEL MUSLIM MEN ARE INDULGING IN 'LOVE JIHAD', FROM 53.1 PER CENT IN JAN. 2023

Q. Do you think reservation should be based only on economic status and not on caste status?



Q. Do you support inter-caste marriages?



All figures in % and rounded off